



Quiet, Then Counted

Built for capacity planning, the library's overflow-desk referral log spends a term tracking names instead

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Background

Library duty staff have informally sent noisy laptop typists and phone callers to a single overflow desk near the entrance for over a decade. A referral log introduced to forecast peak-period demand now runs to hundreds of entries a term. What the log is actually used for is unclear.

Aims

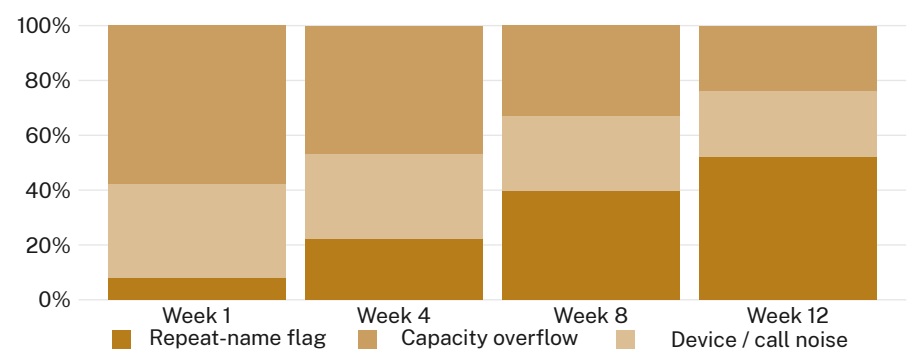
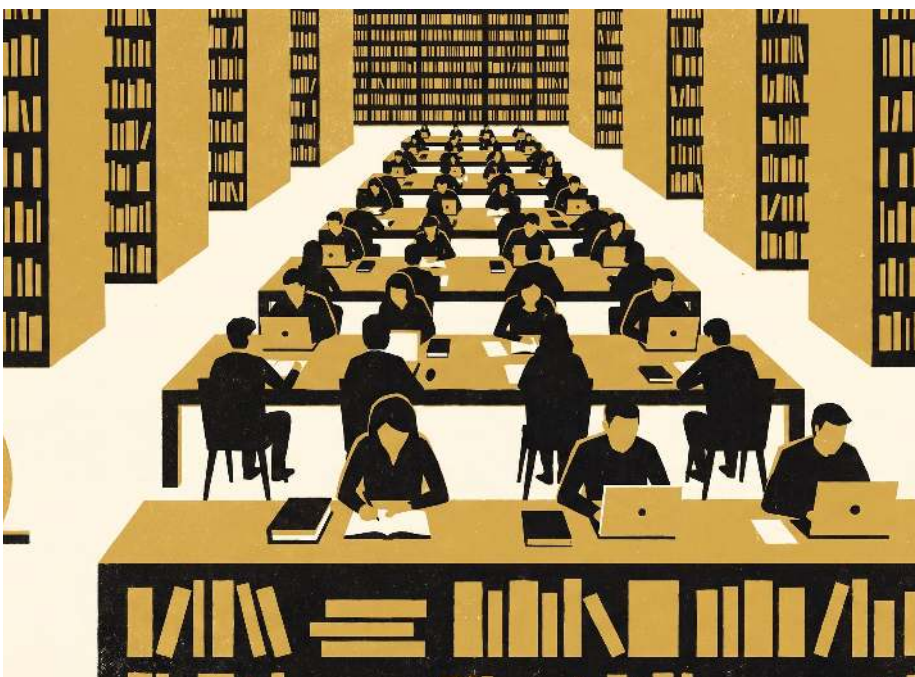
- Code a term's referral-log entries against their stated intake reason
- Interview duty staff on how the log is actually consulted
- Compare coded categories against the log's founding capacity-planning rationale

Methods

- 187 referral-log entries · 3 library sites · 12-week term
- semi-structured interviews with 9 duty staff
- coding scheme and category boundaries pre-registered; no post-hoc revision

Results

The capacity-overflow reason falls from a majority to a minority share of entries across the term. An undocumented repeat-name flag, absent from the log's own intake form, becomes the largest single category by week 12.



Repeat-name flags rose from 8% of entries in week 1 to 52% by week 12 of Semester 1, 2026, overtaking capacity overflow as the log's leading coded reason.

Discussion & conclusions

Duty staff describe consulting the log "to see if a name's come up before" when triaging new booking disputes — a use its own intake form does not list. The desk's founding capacity-planning rationale appears to survive in name only. Next: a proposal to formally register the flag the log already performs.

References

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Duty-staff interview data de-identified at source; referral-log entries never linked to enrolment records.

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